The Hindu
EDITORIAL ANALYSIS

7th February 2025

PREPARE FOR BANK (PO/ CLERK), SSC,UPSC, State PSC, CAT,CTET,RAILWAY EXAMS,CDS, TET, NDA/AIRFORCE, NET and all Govt. Exams

VOCABULARY

1. Prevalent (प्रचलित)

Meaning: Widespread in a particular area or at a particular time.
Synonyms: Widespread, prevailing, ubiquitous
Antonyms: Rare, unusual, exceptional, uncommon
Example: Malaria is still prevalent in many tropical countries despite medical advancements.

2. Repercussions (परिणाम या प्रभाव)

Meaning: An unintended consequence of an event or action, especially a bad one.
Synonyms: Consequences, effects, fallout, ramifications
Antonyms: Causes, origins, reasons, sources
Example: The economic repercussions of the pandemic were felt across industries worldwide.

VOCABULARY

3. Ostensible (प्रकट रूप से / दिखावटी)

Meaning: Appearing to be true, but not necessarily so.
Synonyms: Apparent, superficial, alleged
Antonyms: Genuine, authentic, real
Example: His ostensible reason for resigning was personal health, but insiders suspected political pressure.

4. Conundrum (पहेली / दुविधा)

Meaning: A confusing or difficult problem or question.
Synonyms: Dilemma, puzzle, predicament
Antonyms: Solution, clarity, answer
Example: The government faces a conundrum in balancing economic growth and environmental protection.

VOCABULARY

5. Ephemeral (क्षणिक / अल्पकालिक)

Meaning: Lasting for a very short time.
Synonyms: Transitory, fleeting, short-lived
Antonyms: Permanent, enduring, lasting
Example: The beauty of a sunset is ephemeral but deeply mesmerizing.

6. Copious (प्रचुर)

Meaning: Abundant in supply or quantity.
Synonyms: Ample, plentiful, abundant
Antonyms: Scarce, sparse, lacking
Example: The author took copious notes during the interview.

VOCABULARY

7. Hone (निखारना)

Meaning: To refine or perfect something over a period of time.
Synonyms: Sharpen, improve, enhance
Antonyms: Blunt, dull, worsen
Example: She spent years honing her skills as a dancer.

8. Euphoria (उत्साह)

Meaning: A feeling or state of intense excitement and happiness.
Synonyms: Elation, joy, bliss
Antonyms: Despair, misery, gloom
Example: There was a sense of euphoria in the crowd as the concert began.

VOCABULARY

9. Teeter (डगमगाना)

Meaning: Move or balance unsteadily; sway back and forth.
Synonyms: Wobble, totter, sway, stagger
Antonyms: Stabilize, steady, balance
Example: The company’s finances began to teeter after the market downturn.

10. Wrest (छीनना)

Meaning: Forcibly pull (something) from a person's grasp.
Synonyms: Seize, snatch, grab, take by force
Antonyms: Give, release, relinquish
Example: The rebels managed to wrest control of the capital after a fierce battle.

VOCABULARY

Phrasal Verbs:

1. Head up
Meaning – To lead or be in charge of something.

2. Mess with
Meaning – To interfere with or provoke someone/something.

3. Pan out
Meaning – To turn out or result in a particular way, often successfully.

4. Queer up
Meaning – To spoil, ruin, or make something problematic.

VOCABULARY

Idioms & Phrases

1. At the drop of a hat

Meaning – Immediately; without hesitation.

2. Pass with flying colours

Meaning – To succeed brilliantly or with distinction.

3. Speak of the devil

Meaning – Said when a person appears just after being mentioned.

VOCABULARY

4. Storm in a teacup

Meaning – A lot of fuss over something trivial.

5. Slice the pie

Meaning - To the distribution or division of something, like resources, profits, or responsibilities.

Article for Reading

Crippling aid work: on the U.S.’s freeze on foreign assistance

Insularity often stems from contempt, and the kind now being exhibited by U.S. President Donald Trump and his administration is no exception. Withdrawing from international commitments has become a defining feature of Mr. Trump's foreign policy, and the latest decision to freeze foreign assistance adds to the list of drastic moves, following the withdrawal from WHO and the Paris Accord. This decision will disrupt established global aid structures and have dire consequences for the millions who rely on U.S. assistance for survival. While the full impact is yet to unfold, it is clear to those in the development sector that a cascade of negative repercussions is imminent. On his first day in office, Mr. Trump imposed a 90-day freeze on foreign assistance, citing inefficiencies and ideological opposition to USAID. His administration argues that USAID misallocates funds and operates at odds with his policies.

Elon Musk, head of the Department of Government Efficiency, went so far as to label USAID a viper's nest of radical-left Marxists who hate America. The official USAID website has been stripped of its content, but announced that all personnel would be placed on administrative leave, with only a few exceptions for mission-critical staff. The administration also ordered the rapid repatriation of overseas USAID personnel within 30 days. USAID was established in 1961 as an independent agency under the Foreign Assistance Act, designed to provide global humanitarian and development aid. According to the U.S. government's official spending tracker (USASpending.gov), USAID was allocated $44.2 billion in the 2024 budget. While this amounts to just 0.4% of the total U.S. federal budget, media reports indicate that it accounted for nearly 42% of all humanitarian aid tracked by the UN in 2024. USAID funds a range of programmes which include health care, food aid (including assistance to Gaza), and policy advocacy.

The agency has maintained a strong presence in India since the 1960s, supporting initiatives in education, immunisation, HIV/TB prevention, polio eradication, and child health. Though direct financial aid to India has declined in recent years, USAID contributions still amounted to over $150 million for the latest fiscal year. However, in many conflict-ridden regions, USAID remains a lifeline. Withdrawing from international aid efforts is more than a bureaucratic shift: it risks leaving millions without food, medical assistance and critical resources. The decision reflects an inward-looking approach that dismisses the interconnectedness of global affairs. As the U.S. retreats from its historical leadership in international development, the world will be left grappling with the consequences of this reckless policy shift.

Summary

U.S. President Donald Trump's administration has intensified its withdrawal from international commitments, now freezing foreign aid, following previous exits from the WHO and the Paris Accord. This decision severely impacts global aid structures, endangering millions who depend on U.S. assistance. The freeze, initiated by Trump on his first day in office, is justified by claims of inefficiencies and ideological misalignment within USAID, which has been largely dismantled, with personnel repatriated and its website stripped of content. USAID, established in 1961, played a key role in global humanitarian aid, allocating $44.2 billion in 2024, nearly 42% of all UN-tracked aid. Despite reduced funding to India, the agency still contributed over $150 million last fiscal year. In conflict zones, USAID remains a critical support system, and its withdrawal threatens food security, healthcare, and crisis relief. This move signals a broader isolationist stance, disregarding the interconnected nature of global affairs and diminishing the U.S.'s leadership in international development.

Tone:

The tone of the passage is critical and concerned, highlighting the potentially severe consequences of the U.S.'s foreign aid freeze while portraying the decision as reckless and inward-looking.

Reading Comprehension

Based on the above passage, answer the following questions:

Question 1:
Which of the following best describes the impact of freezing USAID assistance?

a) It will mainly affect U.S. domestic programs and have little global effect.
b) It will primarily hurt developing nations that rely on U.S. aid for survival.
c) It will have no long-term impact as other nations will step in to provide aid.
d) The decision will lead to stronger U.S. alliances by reducing international tensions.
e) None of the above

Question 2:
What does the passage suggest about USAID's historical role in India?

a) USAID has played a crucial role in India's development since the 1960s.
b) USAID's financial contributions to India have increased over time.
c) USAID has only provided financial aid, not development programs.
d) USAID's work in India has been criticized for failing to address key issues.
e) None of the above

Question 3:
Why does the passage argue that withdrawing from USAID commitments is risky?

a) It will primarily benefit authoritarian regimes that oppose U.S. policies.
b) It will improve global aid efficiency by reducing unnecessary spending.
c) It will lead to an increase in U.S. military spending instead.
d) It will weaken U.S. global influence and leadership in international development.
e) None of the above

Article for Skimming

The saga of regulating India’s thermal power emissions

On December 30, 2024, India's Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) issued a notification amending the Environment Protection Rules by pushing back the deadline for thermal plants to comply with sulphur dioxide (SO2) emission norms by three years without any reasons being given. As it happens, the existing deadline for about 20 gigawatts (GW) of thermal plants, all located in close proximity to densely populated areas, was December 31, 2024. This is the latest instance in a nearly decade-long saga that fans of Franz Kafka would find appealing. The MoEFCC revised the emission norms for Indian thermal plants in December 2015 after public consultations, and all thermal plants were expected to comply with them by December 2017 despite it being a tight deadline. This notification tightened the prevalent norms for particulate matter emissions and introduced norms for other emissions, including SO2, for the first time. These norms were understood to be broadly on a par with existing practices in countries such as Australia, China and the United States.

Indian coal generally has a lower sulphur content than other coal, which should have made it easier for Indian thermal plants to meet the SO2 emission norms. But rather than focusing on the best ways to meet the norms — given Indian coal's characteristics — the debate morphed into the challenges around implementing the flue gas desulphurisation (FGD) technology for desulphurisation of high-sulphur coal. Despite the norms never mandating FGDs, the discussion became one about issues such as the scheduling of FGD installations given their long gestation periods and the likely costs of installing them. In parallel, a different discourse questioning the SO2 emission norms themselves also took shape, often driven by different arms of the government. The Central Electricity Authority (CEA) published papers in 2020 and 2021, questioning the need for uniform norms across the country and proposing that its country-wide implementation be phased out till 2035.

The CEA also commissioned a study from IIT Delhi in 2022 which concluded that the installation of FGDs does provide air quality benefits but argued for extending the timelines due to issues such as FGDs being expensive, their supply chain being inadequate, and their operation leading to increased coal consumption (and hence greenhouse gas emissions).

In 2024, NITI Aayog commissioned the CSIR-National Environmental Engineering Research Institute to conduct a study on this. This study concluded that SO2 emission norms are not important to achieve good ambient air quality in India, and instead the focus should be on particulate emissions. There was also one strand of debate about secondary aerosol formation from SO2 emissions as the reason to have norms for it even though Indian coal is relatively low sulphur. Thus, rather than debating these issues and building a consensus before notifying the first set of norms, it continues robustly nearly a decade after their notification.

Question 4:
Which of the following best describes the findings of the NITI Aayog-commissioned study on SO_2 emissions?

a) SO_2 emissions should be the primary focus of environmental regulation in India.
b) Achieving good ambient air quality does not necessarily require strict SO_2 emission norms.
c) FGD installations are cost-effective and should be implemented immediately.
d) Indian coal has high sulphur content, necessitating stringent SO_2 emission norms.
e) None of the above

Question 5

What is the main reason given for opposing immediate implementation of SO_2 norms?

a) The higher sulphur content of Indian coal, making compliance impossible.
b) The lack of parliamentary approval for enforcing stricter environmental norms.
c) The cost and logistical challenges of installing FGDs in thermal power plants.
d) The lack of public support for environmental regulations in India.
e) None of the above

Today's Descriptive Question

Original Text:

El Niño is a climate phenomenon characterized by the warming of sea surface temperatures in the central and eastern Pacific Ocean. It disrupts global weather patterns, leading to extreme climatic events such as droughts, floods, and hurricanes. Occurring every two to seven years, El Niño is part of the El Niño-Southern Oscillation (ENSO) cycle, which also includes La Niña (its cooling counterpart) and a neutral phase.

The warming of Pacific waters weakens the trade winds, altering ocean currents and disrupting normal weather systems worldwide. In India and Southeast Asia, El Niño is linked to weak monsoons, causing droughts and agricultural distress. In contrast, North and South America often experience heavy rainfall and flooding.

El Niño also impacts global food production, fisheries, and ecosystems by affecting ocean temperatures and nutrient availability.

The economic consequences of El Niño can be severe, affecting agriculture, water resources, and energy production. Governments and meteorological agencies closely monitor sea surface temperatures and atmospheric conditions to predict El Niño events and mitigate their effects through disaster preparedness, water conservation, and adaptive farming techniques.

As climate change intensifies, the frequency and intensity of El Niño events may increase, making its study crucial for global climate resilience. Understanding El Niño helps countries prepare for its effects and develop strategies to minimize economic and environmental damage.

Precis:

El Niño is a climate phenomenon causing Pacific Ocean warming and disrupting global weather patterns. It leads to droughts in India and Southeast Asia while bringing heavy rains to the Americas. The event impacts agriculture, fisheries, and economies, making early monitoring essential.

With climate change potentially increasing its intensity, El Niño's study is vital for disaster preparedness and global climate resilience, helping nations minimize environmental and economic losses.

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Looking forward to your support.

Best regards,
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Match the column

1. At the drop of a hat	A. To the distribution or division of something
2. Pass with flying colours	B. Immediately; without hesitation
3. Speak of the devil	C. A lot of fuss over something trivial
4. Storm in a teacup	D. Said when a person appears just after being mentioned
5. Slice the pie	E. To succeed brilliantly or with distinction

Answer:

1-b
2-e
3-d
4-c
5-a

Vocabulary

1. Prevalent:
2. Repercussions:
3. Ostensible:
4. Conundrum:
5. Ephemeral:
6. Copious:
7. Hone:
8. Euphoria:
9. Teeter:
10. Wrest:

Rc ans

1.

Ans: b

Explanation:

Reference: "Withdrawing from international aid efforts is more than a bureaucratic shift: it risks leaving millions without food, medical assistance and critical resources."

The passage states that USAID funds health care, food aid, and humanitarian programs, particularly in conflict-ridden areas, and that millions depend on it for survival. The withdrawal disrupts global aid structures, making the consequences dire.

Incorrect Options:

a) The decision does not impact U.S. domestic programs.

c) The passage suggests negative repercussions rather than a smooth transition to other donors.

d) The move is described as "reckless" and "insular," likely worsening tensions.

2.
Ans: a
Explanation:
Reference: "The agency has maintained a strong presence in India since the 1960s, supporting initiatives in education, immunisation, HIV/TB prevention, polio eradication, and child health."

The passage states that USAID has been active in India since the 1960s, supporting programs related to education, immunization, polio eradication, and child health.

Incorrect Options:

b) The passage notes that direct financial aid to India has declined, contradicting this option.
c) USAID is involved in development programs, not just financial aid.
d) The passage does not mention criticism of USAID’s work in India.

3.
Ans: d
Explanation:
Reference: "As the U.S. retreats from its historical leadership in international development, the world will be left grappling with the consequences of this reckless policy shift."
The passage argues that withdrawing from international aid efforts is not just a bureaucratic shift but a "reckless policy shift" that diminishes U.S. leadership and global influence.

Incorrect Options:

a) While withdrawing aid may create instability, the passage does not state that it will benefit authoritarian regimes.
b) The passage does not claim the freeze will improve efficiency.
c) No mention is made of redirecting funds to the military.

4.

Ans: b

Explanation:

Reference: "This study concluded that SO_2 emission norms are not important to achieve good ambient air quality in India, and instead the focus should be on particulate emissions."

The passage states that the CSIR-National Environmental Engineering Research Institute, commissioned by NITI Aayog, concluded that SO_2 emission norms are not crucial for air quality, and efforts should instead focus on particulate emissions.

Incorrect Options:

a) The study downplayed the importance of SO_2 norms, rather than emphasizing them.
c) The study argued that FGDs are expensive and warrant timeline extensions.
d) Indian coal is described as low in sulphur, contradicting this option.

5.

Ans: c

Explanation:

Reference: "The CEA also commissioned a study from IIT Delhi in 2022 which concluded that the installation of FGDs does provide air quality benefits but argued for extending the timelines due to issues such as FGDs being expensive, their supply chain being inadequate, and their operation leading to increased coal consumption."

The passage mentions that FGDs were not mandated, but discussions focused on their costs, supply chain issues, and operational challenges, leading to calls for timeline extensions.

Incorrect Options:

a) Indian coal has low sulphur content, which should make compliance easier, not harder.
b) The passage does not mention a parliamentary approval requirement.
d) Public sentiment on the issue is not discussed.

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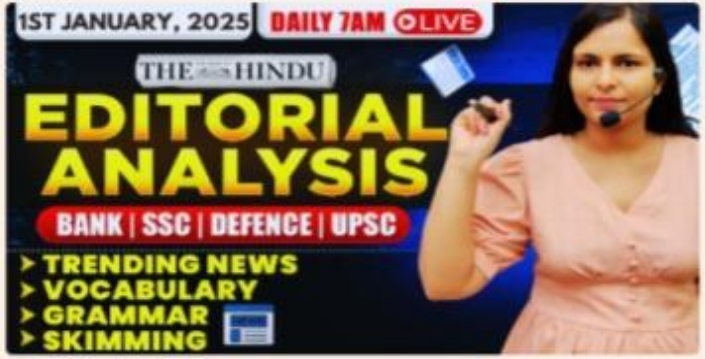

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